



In choppy waters: Indian men's team head coach Igor Stimac has been facing several challenges off the pitch while trying to steer his side. REUTERS

records. More importantly, new challengers emerged, with the dominant USA bowing out early before Spain emerged as the first-time champion. But its crowning moment was overshadowed by Luis Rubiales' unprompted kiss to Jemi Hermoso, which triggered an international outcry as the sport continued to battle with sexism. The following weeks saw Rubiales being dismissed as the Spanish FA president, leading to his ouster from



THE WOMEN'S WORLD CUP IN AUSTRALIA SHATTERED ATTENDANCE AND TV RECORDS



the game for three years by FIFA. Hermoso admitted that the incident took a huge toll on her, and the forward entered the new year by giving evidence to a judge investigating the incident at Spain's highest criminal court.

The four-time world champion USWNT has already made steps towards getting back to the top by appointing Emma Hayes as its new head coach. Hayes is coming to the end of a decade-long trophy-laden stint with Chelsea, where she would want to add the missing Champions League title before crossing the Atlantic.

King of the world: Until recently, Lionel Messi's crowning moment with Argentina appeared elusive, but now he starts the year as the reigning Copa America, World Cup, and Ballon d'Or winner. GETTY IMAGES